Marshall Sam Maneckshaw; Fatima Sana Sheikh plays PM Indira Gandhi. Even Vidya Balan is said to be eager to play Mrs Gandhi, albeit in a web series. In December, in time for Atal Bihari Vajpayee's birthday, will be *Main Atal Hoon*, a biopic with Pankaj Tripathi playing the poet prime minister. But the one that the opposition, particularly the Congress, will be watching with eagle eyes is *SwatantraVeer Savarkar*, co-written and directed by Randeep Hooda, who also plays the titular role. Also, the second instalment of Vivek Agnihotri's "Files" series, focusing this time on the gruesome anti-Sikh riots of 1984, after the right-leaning filmmaker's *The Kashmir Files* stirred controversy and the cash tills.

EMBOLDENING FILMMAKERS IS THE FACT THAT VIVEK AGNIHOTRI'S *THE KASHMIR FILES* RAKED IN Rs 246 CRORE AGAINST A BUDGET OF Rs 25 CRORE

That all the films arrive in the latter half of 2023 and early 2024 when election fever will be at its peak isn't coincidental. *The Kashmir Files* made Rs 246 crore against an estimated budget of Rs 25 crore, convincing creators that it pays to bet on politics.

Cinema-going audiences are also now more open to films with a political bent of mind. In a YouGov-Mint-CPR (Centre for Policy Research) Millennial Survey held in December 2022, 46 per cent of the respondents said that cinema should reflect the nation's "history and political landscape", with 61 per cent being fine with the government promoting films that it considers significant "by making them tax-free, including those with political or historical message". 'Political affiliation and level of partisan attachment are exerting a significant influence on attitudes about cinema's role in a society and a government's role in cinema,' noted the survey, adding that producers now have to tread the fine line between 'content and the politics of their creation'. And if that content happens to be narratives that celebrate the lives and contributions of leaders or organisations favoured by the ruling dispensation, so much the better for the producers.

Enter *Bhagwa Dhwaj*, a drama that chronicles the emergence of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh. It will be written and directed by none other than K.V. Vijayendra Prasad, the writer of *Bahubali I & II* and RRR and father of the celebrated director S.S. Rajamouli. At the launch of Ram Prasad's book *Partitioned Freedom* in Vijayawada in August 2022, K.V., who is also a Rajya Sabha MP, said he was ignorant of the organisation and held misconceived notions about it—["I thought they killed Gandhi]—until he was roped in for the project and visited the RSS headquarters in Nagpur. "I felt a lot of remorse, that I wasn't aware of such a great organisation for so long," he said. "RSS has made one mistake—to not speak of itself to the public. I will make up for this shortcoming as much as I can. I promise I will ensure we can all boast about the greatness of RSS with pride." In an interview to *The New Yorker* this year, Rajamouli described

WHEN OTT WENT POLITICAL

MAHARANI *(SonyLIV)*

Huma Qureshi makes the most of a career-defining role playing a reluctant Chief Minister who confronts and battles patriarchy in Bihar and gradually discovers the the power the position brings. Created by Subhash Kapoor.



TANDAV *(Amazon Prime Video)*

The drama landed the streaming platform in a legal quagmire with objections being raised over 'hurt religious sentiments' and politics. Created by Ali Abbas Zafar.

